

• THE FIELD GUIDE • 2026

SKILL.MD DECODED

A working primer on the file format quietly running every Claude agent — and why it changes how you build with AI.

```
~/agent
$ claude
> /skills/pdf-creator

✓ Loaded SKILL.md
✓ Description matched

claude:
I'll use the pdf-creator
workflow for this task. ■
```

```
/skills

📁 pdf-creator/
├─ SKILL.md
├─ examples/
├─ references/
└─ scripts/

📁 docx-creator/
└─ SKILL.md
```

- REUSABLE
- ON-DEMAND
- PORTABLE

What's a SKILL.md?

SKILL.md

name: pdf-creator

description: Use when
user wants a PDF...

Instructions for the agent

10 SLIDES · 2 MIN READ

THE ANSWER

A single `.md` file
that *teaches* an AI agent
a new skill.

ANATOMY

Three parts. *That's it.*

SKILL.md

...

name:

pdf-creator

ID

description:

Use when user...

TRIGGER

...

Instructions for the agent

BODY

Examples, scripts, refs...

FEATURE 01

Progressive *disclosure*.

UPFRONT

name +
description
~50 tokens

ON-DEMAND

full instructions,
examples, scripts,
assets, refs...

LEAN CONTEXT → BIG CAPABILITY

The model only loads what it needs, when it needs it.

FEATURE 02

Write once. *Run anywhere.*



Claude Code
CLI · IDE · Agents



claude.ai
Web · Mobile · Desktop



The API
Custom runtimes

ONE FILE × EVERY SURFACE

FEATURES 03 + 04

Composable. *Version-controlled.*

/skills

- └─ pdf-creator/
 - └─ SKILL.md
 - └─ examples/
 - └─ scripts/
- └─ docx-creator/
 - └─ SKILL.md
- └─ data-analysis/
 - └─ SKILL.md

Markdown in a folder. Git tracks it. Teams own it.

THE 80/20

The *description* does the work.

It's the trigger condition the model reads to decide whether to load you.

VAGUE

description: Helps with documents.

SPECIFIC

description: Use when user wants to create, read, or edit Word documents (.docx files), including formatting, tables, headers, and tracked changes.

THE SHIFT

prompt engineering



capability
engineering

Stop stuffing context windows. Start building libraries of well-scoped capabilities the model loads on demand.

YOUR TURN

What's the first
SKILL.md
you'd write?

> tell me in the comments

🔄 REPOST

🚩 SAVE

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